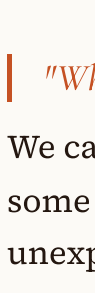


01

EMOTIONAL LITERACY FOR KIDS

Nobody can control everything they feel. But everyone can control *what they do with feelings.*

Your brain is under construction right now — literally. Here's what's actually going on in there, and what to do when your feelings get loud.



Sean Kane
Middle school teacher for twelve years · Dad of three boys

02

FIRST THINGS FIRST

Not all feelings are in *your control.*

| *"Wait, so what are they?"*

Emotions are a response to stimulus. They arise because of chemicals made by your nervous system in response to the things that happen around you and inside of you.

| *"Why can't I control them?"*

We can't always control our environment, so some feelings arrive immediately and unexpectedly. And while our brains are still maturing, we don't always do a good job controlling our thoughts — so some of our worst feelings are generated by our own thoughts.

03

ONE THING YOU SHOULD KNOW

Your brain is *leveling up.*

If you're in middle school, or close to it, you're in puberty. And there are massive brain and hormone shifts happening. They have an impact on your feelings.

| *"Like what?"*

The emotional part of your brain — the **limbic system** — goes into overdrive at first, so sometimes your feelings and reactions will feel out of control.

| *"Is that why I flipped out?"*

That's part of it. Your **amygdala**, another part of your brain that alerts you to danger, is also extra sensitive at this time. It's trying to keep you safe, but it's always overreacting. It will make you overreact to stuff like directions from your parents, your little brother chewing too loud, and that teacher you think hates you.

It's the part of your brain that says "Now's the perfect time TO CRASH OUT."

| *"That's kind of bogus."*

Well, the part of your brain that connects your emotions and behavior is growing up. It's the **prefrontal cortex**. It's basically your brain's strongest muscle — it's a boss — but it has to level up from age 10 to 25.

| *"How do I level it up?"*

Do stuff on purpose, don't be passive. Make good choices. Talk to yourself, ask yourself helpful questions — be like an awesome, supportive version of yourself in your own head.

Every time you stop and think, "Okay, lock in." Or tell yourself, "I'm gonna take a chill pill." Your prefrontal cortex is leading the way. Listen to it. Talk to it.

04

THE PART YOU CONTROL

It's what you *do* with the feelings that matters.

When someone says "control your emotions," what they should say is "control your reactions" — because that's usually what we actually have control over.

Feelings aren't facts. They all go away, good ones and bad ones. So really they're just information — data — a way for your body and brain to communicate with you.

05

THINGS TO DO WITH FEELINGS

Four things that *help.*

→ **Name it.** Saying what you feel, specifically, actually makes feelings less powerful. That's why people journal.

→ **Figure out where it came from.** Finding the origin story of a feeling can help you prevent it — or get more of it. That's why we go to therapy.

→ **Stop ruminating.** Thinking and talking about a feeling non-stop makes it more powerful. That's what makes a person toxic, tbh — they focus on negativity, and it becomes their power.

→ **Practice the good stuff.** Too much cortisol and dopamine make you overwhelmed. And when you feel overwhelmed, you can't access the best part of your brain and make good, healthy choices. That's why you need to practice doing things that are good for you.

✓ THESE PUT YOU IN A BETTER MOOD

Walking, exercising, sleeping, cleaning your room, sunlight, IRL time with friends, laughing, and helping.

They create good **dopamine, serotonin and oxytocin**. That's why adults love the gym, sleeping, and cleaning the house.

THESE PUT STRESS ON YOUR BODY

Complaining, sugar, bedrotting, scrolling, drama, and being rude.

They make **cortisol**. That's why you feel so overstimulated after screen time.

06

KNOW YOUR CHEMICALS

The top 5 human *feeling chemicals.*

Serotonin
stabilizes your mood

1

STIMULATED BY

Sunshine, healthy food, proper rest, and exercise.

IT MAKES YOU FEEL

Calm and in control. Humans need it to feel stable.

IT FEELS LIKE

Waking up to a perfectly calm, organized, clean bedroom.

Oxytocin
creates safe connection

2

STIMULATED BY

Hugs, laughter, and dogs.

IT MAKES YOU FEEL

Safe and loved. Humans need it to stay socially connected and belong.

IT FEELS LIKE

A hug from your favorite human while you also laugh and cry a little.

Dopamine
drives you forward and makes you do stuff

3

STIMULATED BY

Anything you want more of — sugar, salt, scrolling, video games, but also friendship, adventure, ambition, and curiosity.

IT MAKES YOU FEEL

"I want more of that." Humans need it because it motivates us to survive, eat, and make stuff.

IT FEELS LIKE

Craving chips while you're eating the chips.

Cortisol
wakes you up and stresses you out

4

STIMULATED BY

Good and bad stress. It gets your heart, brain, immune system, and digestive system to work. It helps you focus — but it also makes you stressed.

IT MAKES YOU FEEL

Awake, focused, and functional. Humans need just the right amount — it creates energy and focus, and keeps us safe and healthy. But too much actually harms our health.

IT FEELS LIKE

A little bit feels like the first question on a test you studied for. A lot feels like forgetting the test, failing the test, getting yelled at, and feeling like an idiot.

Adrenaline
spikes attention

5

STIMULATED BY

Intense activity — sports, stress, danger.

IT MAKES YOU FEEL

High alert and high energy, fast. Humans need it because it keeps us out of danger.

IT FEELS LIKE

Pounding a monster energy drink while being chased by a pit bull on a dirtbike.

07

A WAY TO PICTURE IT

The lizard and the *wizard.*

During puberty, your amygdala becomes more sensitive and reactive, but your prefrontal cortex isn't completely developed. At first, the lizard runs the show — constantly crashing out. But over time, it learns to listen to the wizard.

THE AMYGDALA

The Lizard

A flinchy, reactive part of your brain that fires up your threat response to keep you alive. It tells you to fight, run away, or freeze from danger.

It's super reactive, sort of immature, and very sensitive. It doesn't always listen.

THE PREFRONTAL CORTEX

The Wizard

The wise, calm, decisive part of your brain that's developing all through adolescence — think Dumbledore.

It helps you make better decisions, but you're still learning to listen to it.

08

TRY IT YOURSELF

What the Wizard asks the *Lizard.*

Here are a few questions you can ask yourself to move away from the amygdala's threat response and toward the control of your prefrontal cortex.

1 What am I really feeling right now? **Be specific.**

2 Where did that feeling come from? Like, why am I angry, scared, irritated, or stressed?

3 Who needs to know how I feel? Was that the best way to express it?

4 What can I do to help that feeling be less intense?

5 What did I learn from this? What should I do now, and next time?

Feelings are information, *not instructions.*

You don't have to obey every feeling. You just have to notice it, name it, and decide what to do next. Every time you do, your prefrontal cortex gets a little stronger — and you get a little more in charge.

Sean Kane
Growth Mindset Parenting · Austin, TX

From Growth Mindset Parenting — the same practices Sean used in room 201, now at the kitchen table.